

was a leading work of music theory in the 18th century.

Seizing opportunity

Rameau took advantage of this opportunity. During the 1730s, he composed a series of operas, including *Castor et Pollux* and *Les Indes Galantes*, which became two of his most popular productions. He retained Lully's varied format, with its mix of spectacles, transformation scenes, and ballet interludes—Lully's works comprise lyric tragedy, the opera-ballet, and the comedy-ballet. Rameau favored a more dynamic approach. He expanded Lully's string orchestra—adding flutes, bassoons, oboes, trumpets, and drums—and created complex harmonic interplays between his choruses and his soloists. “Lully needs actors,” he proclaimed, “but I need singers.”

Altered perceptions

Rameau eventually achieved the same renown as Lully. Many of his later productions were staged at the Paris Opéra or in royal palaces and, in old age, Louis XV honored him with a title, a pension, and the office of royal composer. With the rise of Italian comic opera, however, there was an ironic turnaround in his reputation. In his youth, the critics had dubbed Rameau too Italian (too ornate), but during the “War of the Buffoons” (see [box](#)), pamphleteers mocked him for not being Italian enough, for being a staid representative of the old French school. His reputation was restored in the 20th century.